



Figure 2: The planning and development process as well as the evolution cycle of an e-preneur venture

In case you're not interested in developing the platform in-house, there are some excellent open source e-commerce platforms available. The best among them is OpenCart (<http://www.opencart.com/>). It has all the features of a premium platform, like payment gateway integration, inventory management, catalogue management, etc. It is also supported by a vast community of developers, who publish plug-ins to enhance the platform's functionality. A list of some other open source e-commerce platforms is available at this link (http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_free_and_open_source_eCommerce_software).

One of the key deciding factors in the success of any business is customer support. Customers are more demanding than kids, throw more tantrums than a four-year-old, and are hard to satisfy. The key to a customer's heart is the service and support a business provides once the transaction has been completed. Some great tools in this area are CitrusDB (<http://www.citrusdb.org/>), RT: Request Tracker (<http://bestpractical.com/rt/>), Help Desk Software (<http://freehelpdesk.org/>), etc.

The marketing stage: The next stage in this process is spreading the word about the venture. This requires using various marketing media like emails, media advertisements, newsletters, etc. Though the biggest boost to a marketing effort is happy customers, should you want to take advantage of other media, there are some great open source tools waiting for you, like Openemm (<http://www.openemm.org/>). It provides features like newsletter management, email marketing, etc. It also has a rich interface and excellent reporting features.

Besides this, you can go for advertisements in the social media like Facebook, Twitter, etc. Google Adwords is another great tool, provided you are willing to shell out a few bucks.

Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) is another area which an e-preneur should look into. SEO decides the fate of a website. If your website isn't among the top 10 results of a search engine, you might as well not run it. A great open source tool to handle all your SEO troubles is SEO Panel (<http://www.seopanel.in/>). It provides a vast variety of SEO plug-ins, and has the capability to optimise a website for all the popular search engines.

The expansion and growth stage: Success in the marketing stage indicates that the venture is now ready for expansion and growth. It can be extended to markets that haven't been touched

yet, but promise a greater number of hits or users. Business Intelligence (BI) tools can provide great insights in this area. Some great open source tools for BI are Jaspersoft (<http://www.jaspersoft.com/>), Pentaho (<http://www.pentaho.com/>) and Jedox (<http://www.jedox.com/en/>). All three provide excellent reporting, dashboard and analytics capabilities. The latest release of Jaspersoft uses HTML5 for data visualisations.

The innovation and redesign stage: A major challenge that e-preneurs face is keeping their ventures in line with the latest developments in technologies. Changes in technology take place at a very fast pace; what seems attractive today will become ugly tomorrow. Thus, e-preneurs have to come up with innovative ways to surprise their consumers. I personally feel that the only tools available for this stage are creativity and your imagination. Coupled with the GIMP and the Bluefish editor, they can really enhance the user experience.

The evolution of an e-preneur venture is an ongoing process, and does not end here. Rather, it keeps going through these stages cyclically. Figure 2 shows the stages of planning and developing an e-preneur venture, and the flow of its evolution.

The challenges

Let's now look at some of the risks faced by an e-preneur.

Risk of failure: The chances of an e-preneur venture failing are much higher than any other type of business, because of various factors like competition, threat of substitutes, the threat of new entrants, etc.

Technical risks: The technical risk in an e-preneur venture is very high, as it's highly technology dependent. For example, the website may not be accessible due to servers being down, and hence faces a loss of credibility. The Internet is full of crackers and malicious attackers; it is hard and expensive to safeguard the website from them. Though they can be traced, much of the damage to your venture's credibility would already have been done by then.

Failure to innovate: An e-preneur might not be able to foresee upcoming trends in technology, and hence may fail to make timely innovations. After a certain period, consumers expect to see something new. Failure to surprise them results in loss of customer loyalty.

E-commerce is growing at a rapid pace in our country because people have started accepting the trend of online shopping. Websites like Flipkart.com, Myntra.com, etc. are fast becoming the new hangouts for all kinds of shoppers. In this article, I have attempted to familiarise readers with the basic concepts of e-preneuring, and how they can use open source tools to reduce the investment and time-to-market for their venture. 

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